MODULE 3. Freedom, Culture and Morality

Objectives:

At the end of the module, the students should be able to:

- ✓ Explain why only human beings can be ethical;
- ✓ Discuss the role of freedom in morality;
- ✓ Analyze the relationship of culture to morality; and,
- ✓ Discuss the Filipino Character and Values.

Introduction:

Remember that morality deals with the choices that define who we become and determine our eternal destiny. How we define and use our freedom would clearly affect these defining choices. In fact, it defines how we make these decisions. Whether we see our freedom as license to do whatever we want or as a mission to discern and choose what will make us better people and our lives more fulfilled inform the entire framework in which we make these defining choices. If we are off on how we understand human freedom, or moral compass is inaccurate from the very start.

If we are to choose among possible goods, the goal would be to choose those goods that meet the other goals of natural law – making us more human, choosing and protecting authentic human goodness, being true to our physical and spiritual nature, and enriching human society. For human freedom to fulfill its purpose, we need to have not only the ability to choose, but the ability to choose what can dot the greatest good for us as human beings. Put simply, true human freedom is the ability to choose the best possible good.

Lesson 1. Freedom and Moral Acts

The Role of Freedom in Morality

The personal aspect of morality – which might more properly be called ethics – is about the cultivation of virtue: the development of character traits so that choosing the good becomes a matter of habit. But a person, in order to be truly virtuous, must be free to cultivate the virtues, or not.

There is no virtue in being temperate when you are being forced not to indulge. There is no virtue in being charitable when someone is forcing you to give up what is yours. Virtue can be guided by cultural traditions and social institutions, but it cannot be coerced. A virtuous man must also be a free man.

The interpersonal aspect of morality is more about rule following. These rules are important because, they prevent us from "colliding" with each other. They permit us to live together in harmony, and they also make us recognize, apart from the mere consequences to ourselves, the rights of others. Here too, liberty is essential.

When some people are permitted to dominate others, they treat others as merely a means to an end, rather than ends in themselves. Not only does this fail to honor the basic dignity within each person, it also stifles the flourishing of human potential and creativity. A society of domination will be a society that never reaches its full potential in the human sciences, physical sciences, and creative arts. Liberty affords us the greatest space possible to pursue our projects, in a way that enables us to live well with one another.

Having a final end does not prevent the need for liberty. Freedom remains essential. Freedom is so precious that God will not override it, even when we badly misuse that freedom. In other words, we can't get where we're going if we're not free to walk the road. Thus, freedom is essential to a genuinely good human life at all levels of morality.

Freedom: The Foundation of Moral Act

Freedom is humans' greatest quality and it is a reflection of our creator. Freedom is the power rooted in reason and will, to act or not to act, to do this or that and so to perform deliberate actions on one's own responsibility. Having freedom mean having responsibility. Every action you choose further determines our character.

Are animals free? Do they have freedom? What separates human from animals? Reason (intellect) and will (moral action). Freedom is a power rooted in reason and will, to act or not to act. Good and evil are forged in freedom. To the degree that a person reaches higher level of freedom, he becomes capable of higher levels of morality. The sinful person becomes slave.

The existence of freedom is a central premise in Christian morality. Our secular culture greatly exalts freedom. Yet it also questions whether freedom really exists.

Freedom and Free Will

While the existence of freedom is a central premise in Christian morality, we are not all equally free. There are many possible limits to our freedom both external and internal. External freedom is a freedom from factors outside ourselves that limit or destroy our free will. Internal freedom is a freedom from interior factors that limit our free will.

Requirement of True Freedom

True freedom is dependent upon truth, "You will know the truth, and the truth will set you free" (John 8:32). Example, lying to a teacher or to a friend. True freedom is oriented toward the good. We should not understand freedom as the possibility of doing evil. Evil enslaves us and diminishes our ability to be free. True freedom requires responsibility. There is no such thing as irresponsible freedom.

Human Acts vs. Acts of Humans

Human acts make use of his knowledge and free will. Example, love your enemy, pray to God, and sacrifice for others. Acts of human do not make use of his intellect or will knowledge. His action is natural. Examples of acts of human are breathing, blinking, and sneezing.

True freedom liberates us to develop our God-given talents in a responsible way so we can live our lives for others and for God. True freedom serves what is good, just and true.

Man is created by God as a human person who can begin and control his own actions. He is meant to seek God and gain perfection by clinging to him. By freedom which is rooted in his intellect and will, man has the power to act or not to act. He can shape his own life, mature in goodness, and gain a perfection which is rooted in God. Until man attains God, he can choose to do good or evil, to grow in perfection or to sin. Because human acts are free, they are worthy of praise or blame. By constantly doing what is good, man grows in freedom. Doing evil leads man into a "slavery of sin" (Rom 6:17).

A person is responsible for his voluntary acts. By progress in virtue, in knowledge of good, and in self-discipline, he gains greater mastery. Man's responsibility and imputability can be lessened or nullified by ignorance, fear, habits, or inordinate attachments or other factors.

God confronted Eve, "*What is this that you have done?"* (Gen. 3:13). He also confronted Cain, "*What have you done?"* (Gen. 4:10). A person is responsible for any directly willed act. Also, an action can be indirectly voluntary (from negligence or ignorance). A person is not responsible for an evil act if he did not will it and did not intend it as a means to an end. For example, a person might incur death while trying to help another. A person is responsible if they could have avoided the evil as a drunk driver killing someone.

Every human person must recognize the right of freedom in others. Exercising freedom, especially in moral or religious matters, is an inalienable right of the human person. This must be protected by civil authorities within the limits of public order.

Human freedom who refused God's love becomes a slave to sin. The first sin has led to so many others. Human history attests that the problems of man come from man's abuse of freedom. Freedom does not give man the right to say and do everything, because man's purpose is not his own earthly satisfaction. Man's blindness and injustice destroy the cultural conditions needed for freedom. Deviating from the moral law violates man's own freedom and imprisons him within himself.

"*For freedom*, *Christ has set us free"* (Gal. 5:1) and saved us from sin's power. "*When the Spirit of the Lord is, there is freedom*" (1 Cor. 17).

Christ's grace is not a rival to man's freedom. The person grows in inner freedom by being docile to God's Spirit. "*Take away from us all that is harmful so we may freely accomplish your will*".

Whenever man deliberately chooses, he is the "father of his acts". These freely chosen acts can be morally evaluated as good or evil.

The objects directly chosen by the will determines the basic morality (good or bad). The person's intellect sees this as according to moral standards (good) or not according to moral standards (evil).

The person also has an intention which determines the act's morality. An intention can guide many acts or even a whole lifetime (as loving God). One act can have a multiplicity of intentions (Doing a favor to help someone and also to receive a favor in return).

However, a good intention can never turn an evil act into a good one. A good purpose cannot justify evil means. However, an evil intention can make a good act into an evil one, such as giving alms to gain praise.

Only the act and the intention make an act good or bad. The circumstances can increase or diminish the goodness or evil. For example, stealing a large amount of money increases the evil, while fear of harm can lessen a person's responsibility. Circumstances can never make an evil act into a good one.

An act is good when the object, the intention, and the circumstances are all good. A good act is destroyed by an evil intention like praying in order to be seen as good. Some acts are evil in themselves as fornication and are always wrong to choose. Therefore, the person's intention and the circumstances, such as pressure or duress, cannot change a morally evil act, such as murder, blasphemy, or adultery, into a morally good act. We cannot do evil so good will come from it.

Lesson 2. Culture and Morality

In a review essay on morality and culture, Mary Douglas pointed out that there exists little communications between anthropologists writing on morals and the (western) moral philosophers. Anthropological findings enter the discussions as '*exotic examples*'. She expects this situation to last for quite some time.

Two conversations are running parallel: one the philosophers', about the rational foundation of ethics, another the anthropologists', about the interaction between moral ideas and social institutions. The conversations, as they are set at the present time, seems will never converge.

Anthropologists are confident that they are speaking about the role of culture in human life and societies. Moral philosophers are sure that they are discussing moral issues. So far so good. But the problem begins when anthropologists turn to the investigation of the morality of a culture and when philosophers try to account for the role of culture in the formation of morality. The central difficulty has to do with the way the relation between morality and culture is perceived.

In fact, the problem is more fundamental than Douglas assumes. According to her, it is possible to reduce the gap between anthropologists and philosophers if the latter were to give up some of their (culturally determined) views on morality. True, but this is not the whole story. The anthropologists have difficulties too while accounting for the morality that philosophers speak about.

What is Culture?

Culture is derived from the Latin word "***cultura"*** or "***cultus***" which means care or cultivation. Culture as cultivation implies that every human being is a potential member of his own social group. He is endowed with certain innate qualities to make use. However, he cannot develop these inborn talents without the other people. He/she needs other people who can provide him/her with the needed opportunities so he/she can translate these potentialities into realities called achievements. These accomplishments not only help him achieve self-actualization but also make him/her a contributing member of his society.

Anthropologist Edward B. Tylor, an Englishman, developed one of the classic definition of culture. He said, "*Culture is that complex whole which includes knowledge, belief, law, art, moral, custom, and other capabilities and habits acquired as a member of society.*" In other word, culture refers to the totality of the humanly created world, from material culture and cultivated landscapes, via social institutions (political, religious, economic etc.), to knowledge and meaning something that human has created and learned in society. His theory defines culture in descriptive terms as the "complex whole" that makes up social ideas and institutions.

In Tylor's view, culture includes all aspects of human activity, from the fine arts to popular entertainment, from everyday behavior to the development of sophisticated technology. It contains the plan, rules, techniques, designs and policies for living.

On the other hand, sociologists defined culture as the entire way of life followed by people, and everything learned and shared by people in society. (Hunt et. al. 1994). According to Landis (1992), culture is a complex set of learned and shared beliefs, customs, skills, habits, traditions and knowledge common to members of society.

The Influence of Culture in Moral Development

Culture has been with us since the dawn of human existence. Significant as it is, considerably shapes its members on how they live and relate within themselves and with other cultures (Bretzke, 2004).

Culture is a social environment in which a person is born and wherein he or she lives together with other persons. Hence, culture has a great impact in the development of the human person in varied ways; may it be in physical, knowledge, thought, relationship, religious or moral development.

Moreover, culture is a person's social heritage that has been passed from one generation to the next basically through the relationship that binds the society together. It necessarily says on what are the things a member of the society must do, what to do and how to do things. It teaches and conditions members on how to relate and live with the other members of the society and even to people outside of their own culture.

At its fundamentals, culture has important characteristics. As I would emphasize, culture is rooted from the collective "human experience". Culture is always transmitted, shared or acquired through learning. Culture satisfies human needs as a social being. And culture tends towards the participation of the members of the society.

Therefore, culture functions to mold and establish a social identity that brings people as well to the knowledge of common objectives which members would try to achieve. Culture, indeed, provides norms, customs, laws, and moral demands that are to be followed. So to speak, in general, in a culture there is consistency and systematic patterns of behavior (Palispis, 2007).

In general, culture plays a vital role in the development of the human person. In every aspect of the human person, the cultural background can be very visible. In particular, culture has an essential influence on the moral development of the human person since morality is just one of the cultural aspects.

Culture would tell, as I have mentioned above, the members on what to do, how to do things, and what are the things that should be done as well as those things that should be avoided. So to speak, culture imprints the existing moral principles into its members, thus, shapes the character of its members as well. Indeed, this is a process from infancy to adulthood, effectively presented by Kohlberg in his theory on the stages of moral development.

At this point let us particularize how culture influence the moral development of the people. The points below are the following:

1. Culture is always communal by which the relationship of the people towards one another and their experience as a people are the culture's field. Morality as principle is promoted because primarily of the relationship within the community, and as it is handed down from one generation to another forms as well the morality of that particular generation. Yet, the kind of morality may not be absolutely the same with the previous generation due to changes that would inevitably occur.

2. Culture defines the normative principles and behaviors of the society. It defines which particular principle and behavior that should be kept that would serve the best interest of the community. There would be a definition on what are the principles and behaviors also that should not be promoted or rejected.

3. Culture develops restrictions and sets boundaries and limitations as they live and relate with one another. These restrictions and boundaries serve as protection among themselves. These would create an atmosphere of promoting the welfare of the community. Anyone who tries to step beyond this is subject to punishment or consequences set by the community embedded in the culture.

4. Culture helps in generating the character and identity of its people, it also includes their moral character. It conditions the mind – the way people think and the way they perceive the world and their relationship with one another. The character that is being shaped by a culture may not always be just and rightful. A culture like many others may shape a character that is unjust and mistaken in the general perspective of human morality.

5. Culture identifies the authorities or the governing individuals or groups. They are symbol of guidance and control. By their very authority as they represent the general populace, the members look at them as people who promote and keep the set of rules and laws that govern the community. In particular, in domestic level the parents of a child are the first authorities who set and teach the child essential for the moral development of their child.

Evidently, culture is very significant in the development of the human person and in moral development particularly. Furthermore, as one would look at it, culture has a tight grip on the moral development of the people. Culture is the conditioning principle of the moral development of its members. Nevertheless, culture as the principle that surrounds the moral development of the people may not always promote what is good and just for all. It is certain that sometimes there are principles, attitudes and behaviors that actually hinder good relationships and violate the welfare of the others. These are indeed difficult to eliminate immediately in a culture, yet, they should be subject to people's discernment that proper changes and modifications have to be done for the sake of the welfare and justice of everybody.

Cultural Relativism

The cross-cultural relationship is the idea that people from different cultures can have relationships that acknowledge, respect and begin to understand each other's diverse lives. People with different backgrounds can help each other see possibilities that they never thought were there because of limitations, or cultural proscriptions, posed by their own traditions. Traditional practices in certain cultures can restrict opportunity because they are "wrong" according to one specific culture. Becoming aware of these new possibilities will ultimately change the people that are exposed to the new ideas. This cross-cultural relationship provides hope that new opportunities will be discovered but at the same time it is threatening. The threat is that once the relationship occurs, one can no longer claim that any single culture is the absolute truth.

The concept of cultural relativism as we know and use it today was established as an analytic tool by German-American anthropologist Franz Boas in the early 20th century. ***Cultural Relativism*** is the ability to understand a culture on its own terms and not to make judgments using the standards of one's own culture. The goal of this is promote understanding of cultural practices that are not typically part of one's own culture. Using the perspective of cultural relativism leads to the view that no one culture is superior than another culture when compared to the systems of morality, law, politics, etc. It is a concept that cultural norms and values derive their meaning within a specific social context. This is also based on the idea that there is no absolute standard of good or evil, therefore every decision and judgment of what is right and wrong is individually decided in each society.

Advantages of Cultural Relativism

1. It is a system which promotes cooperation.
2. It creates a society where equality is possible.
3. People can pursue a genuine interest.
4. Respect is encourage in a system of cultural relativism.
5. It preserves human cultures.
6. Cultural relativism creates a society without judgment.
7. Moral relativism can be excluded from cultural relativism.
8. We can create personal moral codes based on societal standards with ease.
9. It stops cultural conditioning.

Disadvantages of Cultural Relativism

1. It creates a system that is fueled by personal bias.
2. It would create chaos.
3. It is an idea that is based on the perfection of humanity.
4. It could promote a lack of diversity.
5. It draws people away from one another.
6. It could limit moral progress.
7. It could limit humanity's progress.
8. Cultural relativism can turn perceptions into truth.

The cultural relativism's advantages and disadvantages which are discussed are based on the theoretical implementation of such a system. Originally proposed by Franz Boas in 1887, it is an idea that has never been implemented on a large scale. Moral standards make sense in a person's culture. By creating individualized cultures, on singular or larger scales, it does become easier to keep and embrace traditions that humanity has developed over the millennia.

Lesson 3. The Filipino Way – Filipino Culture and Values

Our culture is a big reflection of our great and complex history. It is influenced by most of the people we have interacted with. A blend of the Malayo-Polynesian and Hispanic culture with the influence from Chinese, Indian, Arabs, and other Asian cultures really contribute to the customs and traditions of the Filipinos.

Filipino culture is unique compared to other Asian countries, and beliefs applied every day in the life of the Filipinos reveal how rich and blessed the culture the people have.

The Filipino Customs and Traditions

What is it about the Philippines that makes it different from the rest of the world? Well, for one thing, it is all about their culture.

When children or young people greet or say goodbye to their elders they typically do so by taking the right hand of the elder with their right hand and place the back of elder's hand lightly on their forehead. It is a way of giving respect to the elders and it is believed that is also a way of receiving blessing to the elders. "*Mano po*" is the term used when kissing the hands of elders.

Mano is a Spanish word for "**hand**" while *po* is used at the end of the sentence when addressing elders or superiors.

The Filipinos are one of the most hospitable people you may find anywhere. Foreign visitors in the country are treated with the utmost respect. This trait is usually seen during fiestas and holidays where many Filipinos are giving their best to entertain their visitors well.

It is amazing to see that even the simplest home along the road opens its doors to a stranger. For Filipinos, to be able to serve others gives them honor of showing true friendship. Filipino hospitality is a trait you can't take away from them.

1. **Having close family ties** is also one of their unique traits. It is one of the outstanding cultural values that Filipinos have. The family takes care of each other and is taught to be loyal to family and elders by simply obeying their authorities. Having fondness for family reunions during secular and religious holidays such as Christmas, New Year's eve, All Saints' Day, Holy Week, fiestas, homecoming, birthdays, weddings, etc. is evidence that Filipino people value not only our cultural traditions but the spirit of our family. As Filipinos, we are blessed to have been brought up with strong family ties.
2. **The *Bayanihan*** – it is the spirit of communal unity or effort to achieve a particular objective. A famous example of this is the neighbors carrying a hut or a house to a new location. People nowadays use it to describe an outpouring of community spirit – as people give their all to the common good, without expecting recognition or personal gain.
3. **Courtship** – We Filipinos are very romantic when it comes to heart affairs. Serenading or *harana* in Tagalog is one of the most popular forms of courtship to show that a man is very serious with his intentions to a woman.
4. **Religion** – the Philippines is one of two predominantly Roman Catholic nations in Asia-Pacific. Their habit of going to church and often praying reflects the Filipinos have a deep faith and belief when it comes to religion. Filipinos believe that having a strong devotion may lead to a better life and their guidance to face everyday life.
5. **Superstition** – these beliefs have come from the different sayings and beliefs of our ancestors that aim to prevent danger from happening or to make a person refrain from doing something in particular. Some are practiced primarily because Filipinos believe that there is nothing to lose if they will comply with these beliefs.
6. **Marriage and Wedding Customs** – in the country, marriage is a sacred union of man and woman after a period of courtship and engagement. It is a sacrament between two people who love each other. For many Filipinos, the eternal quality of dedication to God pervades a truly sacred marriage.
7. **Death** – death in the Philippines is one of the most important occasions in family life. For many Filipinos, a death of a relative is an opportunity to strengthen ties in the family. To pay respect and honor the relationship to the deceased, long lost relatives, friends, and even relatives working abroad are reunited. The Philippines is the home of some unique death rituals that are partly religious and mostly superstitious**.** The mourning and weeping are still present, but a happy and welcoming atmosphere would usually envelop the place to help

the deceased on his/her journey to the afterlife. Other customs includes *pasiyam* and 40 day mourning period.

8. **Society** – the Philippines is a combined society, both singular and plural in form. It is singular as one nation, but plural in that it is fragmented geographically and culturally. Although different in numerous ways, the Filipinos are very hospitable and give appropriate respect to everybody regardless of race, culture and belief.
9. **Christmas in the Philippines** – considered as one of the biggest holidays in the archipelago. We earned the distinction of celebrating the world's longest Christmas season with Christmas carols heard as early as September and lasting until Epiphany. For many Filipinos, the true essence of Christmas is not gift giving but sharing this special holy day with family.
10. **Fiestas** – every town and city in the Philippines has a fiesta of its own; whatever time of the year it is, there sure to be a fiesta going on somewhere. Fiestas in the Philippines are held to celebrate a patron saint. For individual Filipinos, fiestas can be a way of supplicating the heavens or to make amends for past wrongs. It is a way to celebrate their blessings, commemorate their past and observe solemn religious rituals.
11. **Living with parents** – Filipinos highly value the presence of family more than anything. Adult children living with their parents are another Filipino traditional that make them exceptional. Unlike in the United States where children leave the home after finishing high school or college, many Filipinos continue living with parents until they get married. (Abundo, 2015)

Characteristic of Filipino Culture

1. The Filipinos are very resilient.
2. Filipinos take pride in their families.
3. Filipinos are very religious.
4. Filipinos are very respectful.
5. Filipinos help one another.
6. Filipinos value traditions and culture.
7. Filipinos have the longest Christmas celebration.
8. Filipinos love art and architecture.
9. The Filipinos are hospitable people.

Filipino Family Values

The family is the center of the social structure and includes the nuclear family, aunts, uncles, grandparents, cousins and honorary relations such as godparents, sponsors, and close family friends. People get strength and stability from their family. As such, many children have several godparents.

Concern for the extended family is seen in the patronage provided to family members when they seek employment. It is common for members of the same family to work for the same company. In fact, many collective bargaining agreements state that preferential hiring will be given to family members.

The family consists of many traditional values that have been treasured and passed on for many generations already. These values are incredibly beneficial. Hereunder are the following traditional values.

1. Paggalang (respect)
2. Pakikisama (helping others)
3. Utang na loob (debt in gratitude)
4. Pagpapahalaga sa pamilya
5. Hiya (shame)
6. Damayan System
7. Compassionate
8. Fun-loving trait

Social Values of the Filipinos

The great majority of the Philippines is bound together by common values and a common religion. Philippine society is characterized by many positive traits. Among these are:

1. High regard for *amor propio* (Spanish term for self-love, it means self-esteem).
2. Smooth interpersonal relationship.
3. Personal alliance system.
4. The *Compadre system* (bonds of ritual kinship sealed on any of three ceremonial occasions– baptism, confirmation, and marriage).

5. *Utang-na-loob* – a dyadic bond between two individuals, although that the debtor will attempt repayment, it is widely recognized that the debt can never be fully repaid and the obligations can last for generations.
6. *Suki* relationship (market exchange partnership) – may develop between two people who agree to become regular customer and supplier. Because trust is such a vital aspect, it creates a platform for personal relationships that can blossom into genuine friendship between individuals.
7. Friendship – often is placed on at par with kinship as the most central Filipino relationship. A willingness to help one another provides the prime rationale for the relationship.

Weakness of the Filipino Character

1. Passivity and lack of initiative – acceptance of what happens, without active response or resistance.
2. Colonial mentality – colonial mentality more strictly refers to the attitude the Filipinos feel that products coming from other countries are more superior to the local products.
3. *Kanya-kanya* syndrome – Filipinos have a selfish, self-serving attitude that generates a feeling of envy and competitiveness towards others, particularly one's peers who seem to have gained some status or prestige.
4. *Extreme personalism* – there is no separation between an objective task and emotional involvement. This *personalism* is manifested in the tendency to give personal interpretations to actions, i.e. '*walang personalan, trabaho lang*'.
5. *Extreme family centeredness* – excessive concern for family manifests itself in the use of one's office and power as a means of promoting the interest of the family, in factionalism, patronage, and political dynasties and in the protection of erring family members. It results in lack of concern for the common good and it acts as a block to national consciousness.
6. *Lack of discipline*.
7. *Lack of self-analysis and reflection.* – Related to this is the Filipino emphasis on form (*porma*) rather than on substance.
8. *Ningas Cogon – an attitude of being enthusiastic only during the start of new undertakings.*
9. *Gaya-Gaya attitude* – imitating or copying other culture specifically fashion and trends.